



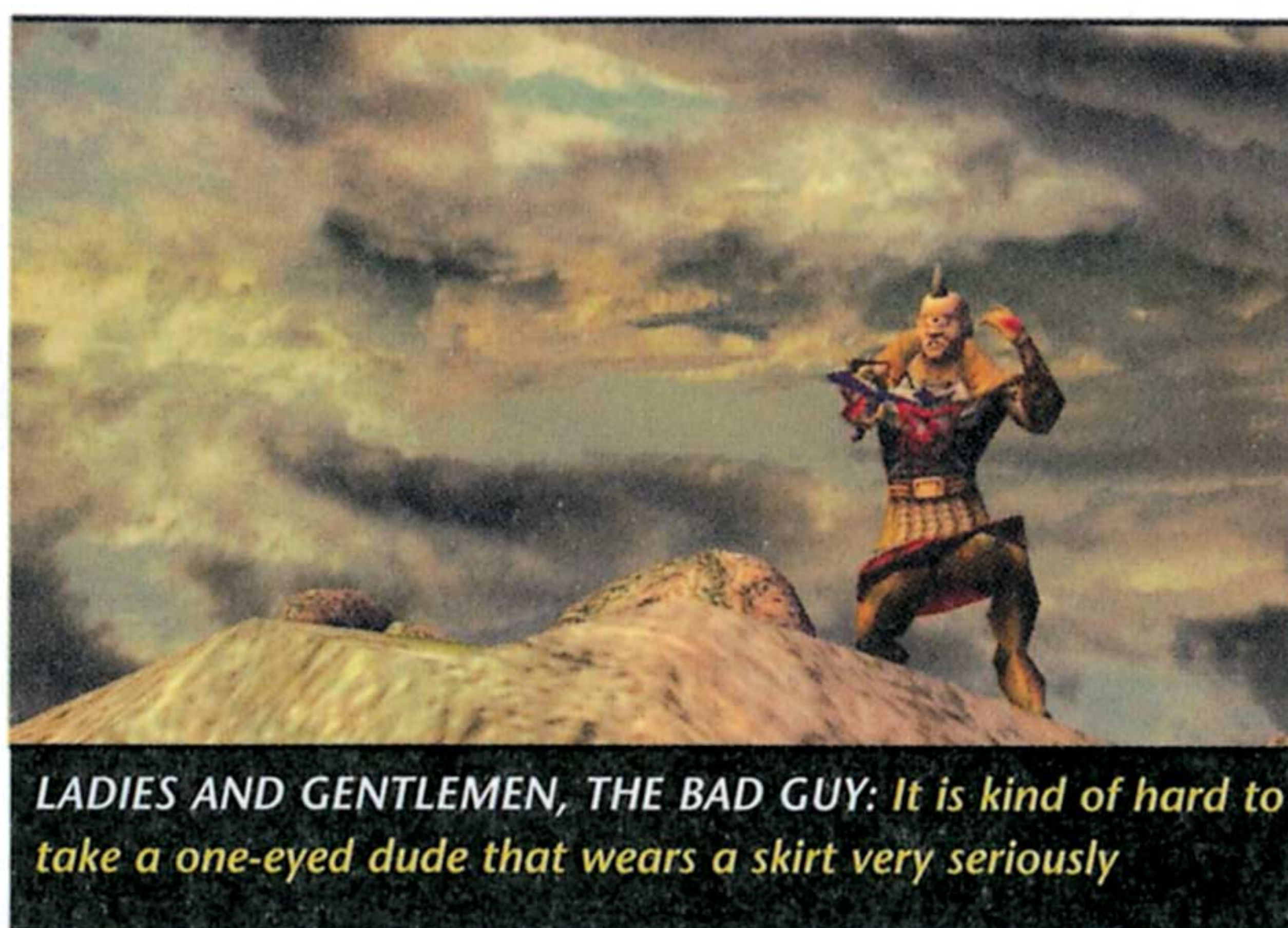
Age of Mythology

Manna from the gods

The Age series of strategy games from Ensemble Studios have reached an interesting existential dilemma: how do you improve upon perfection? The route taken: do not fix what is not broken and add enough variety to keep fans and new players on their toes. The latest in the series, *Age of Mythology* (AOM) faithfully follows the path laid. Enter a world of monsters, heroes and immortals—elements serve to offer the spice.

The game plays in a manner similar to its predecessors and to others in its genre. Make your way through a research tree, hanging on to the branches that help in advancing your war machine; manage resources and then hurl your war machine in the general direction of the ones you abhor, hoping to come out on top.

The resource management comes with a twist in the tail; you have the regular suspects of gold and wood, along with a new element of favour. This is where the gods enter the arena. Each



LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, THE BAD GUY: *It is kind of hard to take a one-eyed dude that wears a skirt very seriously*

civilisation (Greeks, Egyptians and Norse Vikings) has its own legend and cache of gods. There are myth units unique to each of these cultures (giants, chimeras and crocodiles that shoot beams via jewelled foreheads) in addition to heroes that are content to wander the country side killing, crushing, maiming and generally making themselves useful in ways only a hero can.

for thirty seconds.

The paper-stone-scissor element of strategy games takes on two layers in *Age Of Mythologies* heroes do well against myth units, myth units destroy regular units and the regulars are great against heroes when used in numbers. This relationship goes on top of the usual cavalry, archers, and infantry dynamic adding a degree of complexity and strategy.

Prior to starting a game you have to choose one god from a trio, thereafter, every time the game enters a new age, a lesser god is to be chosen. These gods grant favours, myth units and god powers, thus a fair amount of replay value is factored in by your choice of a deity. The god powers can take the form of the simple bolt, granted by Zeus, which kills a single unit instantly to Hermes' gift of cease fire, which stops combat dead

Minimum system requirements: 450 MHz processor, 128 MB RAM, 3D Accelerator card with 16 MB VRAM ■ **Genre:** Real Time Strategy
Developer: Elixir Studios ■ **Distributor:** Microsoft India ■ **Phone:** 022-26294600 ■ **Web site:** www.nolf2.sierra.com ■ **Price:** Rs 1,299
Rating: ★★★★★

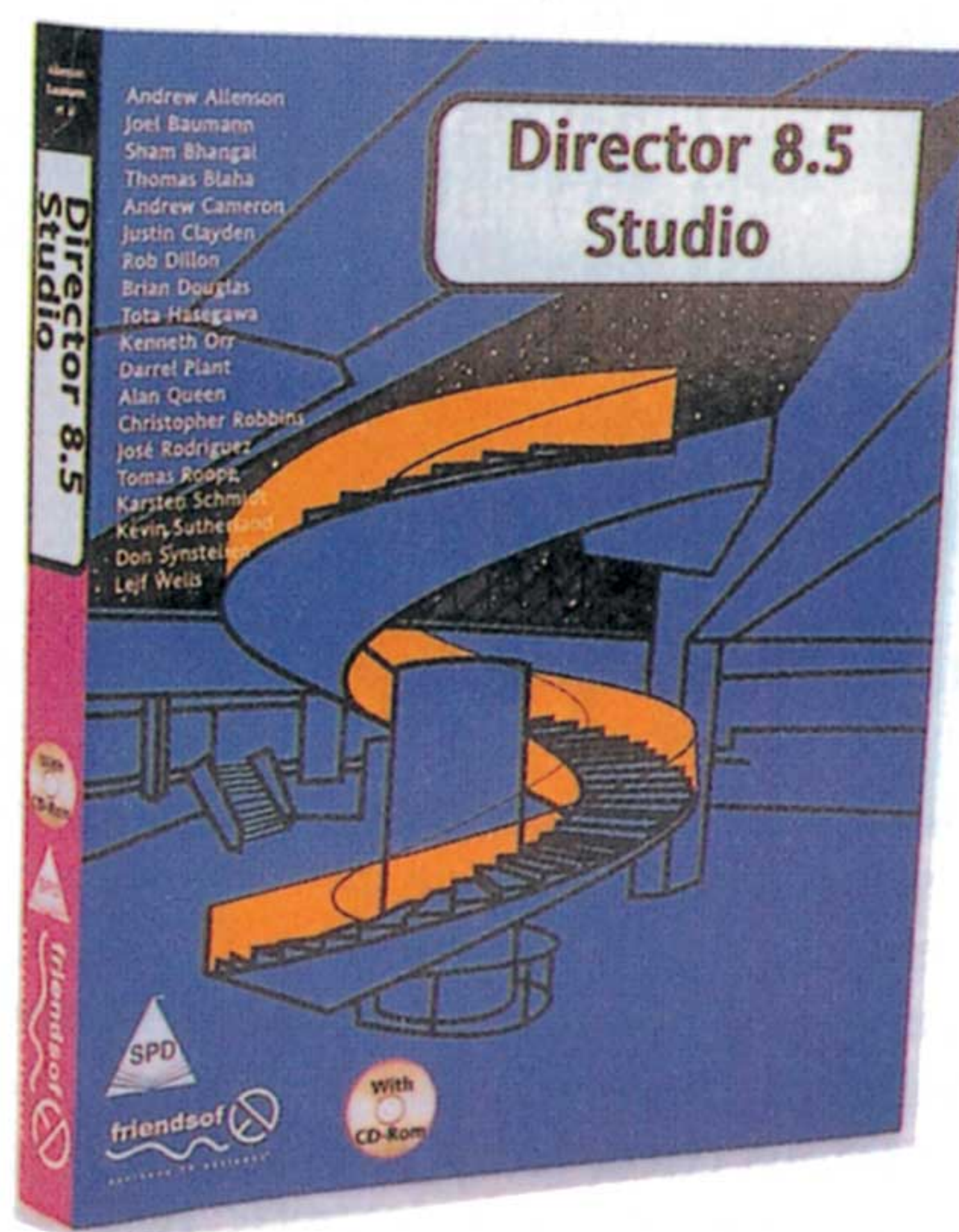


FOUNDATION ILLUSTRATOR 10

Hands-on Illustrator

Director 8.5 Studio, undoubtedly the most widely used multimedia tool, is the latest offering from Macromedia Inc. Its namesake in the book form, Director 8.5 Studio, aids the users of its previous versions to get acquainted with the enhancements.

The book covers each topic extensively, explaining the jargon for first-time users. It delves deeper into lingo programming, real-time 3D creation and editing. The examples are accompanied by descriptive visuals, helping the user to easily understand the functions and real-time capabilities of Director 8.5. The print and page quality too do not disappoint. The book brings along with it a self-learning CD, which



contains interactive tutorials. However, these tutorials are aimed at more experienced users and new users will find the navigation confusing.

Whether you're a seasoned Director user wanting to extend your Director movies into the third dimension or a 3D graphic artist using Director to propel your models into Shockwave and onto the Web, this book, with its accompanying CD, gives you practical, hands-on training. It helps developers integrate both multimedia applications and 3D capabilities with the help of lingo programming. Above all, if you want a head start into development of multimedia-rich applications, this book gives you the much needed push.

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Fax: 022-2623551 ■ **E-mail:** cbsbom@giasbm01.vsnl.net.in ■ **Price:** Rs 600
Rating: ★★★★★